PRESEARCH

Pre-code design document for FleetGraph, grounded in the current Ship codebase and product model.

Working Thesis

FleetGraph should be a project intelligence agent for **execution drift and next-action clarity**.

It should not be a generic chatbot, a second dashboard, or a duplicate of Ship's existing accountability engine. Ship already detects some missing rituals and shows status. FleetGraph should sit one level above that: it should combine graph context, activity, ownership, approvals, and accountability signals to answer:

- What is drifting?
- Why does it matter?
- Who should act?
- What is the best next action?

Repo-Grounded Observations

These decisions are based on what Ship already exposes:

- Ship is a unified-document system. Programs, projects, weeks, issues, people, standups, weekly plans, and retros are all documents connected through associations.
- Ship already has inferred accountability signals at `/api/accountability/action-items`.
- Ship already has urgency and owned-work views at `/api/dashboard/my-work`.
- Ship already has relationship-scoped activity at `/api/activity/:entityType/:entityId`.
- Ship already has team allocation and accountability surfaces at `/api/team/grid`.
- Ship already has context-specific Claude data at `/api/claude/context`.
- Ship already has AI quality assistants for weekly plans and retros at `/api/ai/*` and `QualityAssistant.tsx`.
- Ship already has realtime in-app notification plumbing through `accountability:updated` events in `App.tsx` and `useRealtimeEvents.tsx`.

The implication is simple:

FleetGraph should reuse Ship's existing context surfaces and notification patterns, not invent a parallel product model.

Non-Goals

- Not a standalone chatbot page
- Not a replacement for dashboards, accountability action items, or AI writing assistance
- Not a direct database reader
- Not an auto-pilot that changes project state without review
- Not a generalized knowledge bot for every document in the workspace

Phase 1: Define the Agent

1. Agent Responsibility Scoping

FleetGraph should be defined by the problems it owns, not by the existence of an LLM or a chat box. In Ship, the highest-value problems are not “find me information” problems; they are “something is drifting and the right person is about to miss it” problems. That means the agent’s job is to monitor execution, accountability, approvals, ownership, and intake, then decide when a situation is meaningful enough to surface and who should see it.

This section directly answers:

- What events in Ship should the agent monitor proactively?
- What constitutes a condition worth surfacing?
- What is the agent allowed to do without human approval?
- What must always require confirmation?
- How does the agent know who is on a project?
- How does the agent know who to notify?
- How does the on-demand mode use context from the current view?

What events in Ship should the agent monitor proactively?

FleetGraph should monitor two kinds of proactive triggers:

1. **Mutation events**

- issue created or updated
- issue moved into or out of a sprint
- weekly plan or retro created, submitted, or changed
- week started, approved, or sent back for changes
- project plan or retro changed
- public feedback created or triaged

1. **Time-based conditions discovered by scheduled sweeps**

- missing standups
- missing weekly plans or retros
- active sprint with low activity and open work
- blocked or stale issues
- approval pending too long
- changes requested but not addressed
- feedback sitting in triage too long

The main proactive monitoring areas are:

1. **Execution drift**

- active sprint with low activity and open work
- issues blocked or stale for too long
- project target at risk because child work is not moving

1. **Accountability gaps**

- missing standups
- missing weekly plans or retros
- sprint started but not actually started in Ship
- sprint started with no issues
- project missing plan or retro

1. **Approval bottlenecks**

- plan approval pending too long
- retro approval pending too long
- changes requested but not addressed

1. **Ownership and role gaps**

- project or program missing responsible/accountable owners
- work has assignees but no clear accountable reviewer
- escalation path exists but is not being used

1. **Coordination imbalance**

- one person overloaded across active sprint work
- project owner is carrying risk that should be redistributed
- PM or director attention is needed on a small set of scopes

1. **Intake and triage gaps**

- external feedback enters the system and sits in triage too long
- useful learnings exist but are not connected to active work

What constitutes a condition worth surfacing?

A condition is worth surfacing only if it meets all of these:

- it affects near-term execution, accountability, or decision-making
- it has a clear owner, reviewer, or escalation target
- it implies a specific next step
- it is not a duplicate of a recently surfaced finding
- the agent has enough evidence to explain why it matters

What is the agent allowed to do without human approval?

FleetGraph can autonomously:

- detect and rank findings
- send in-app proactive nudges to the most relevant user
- generate a concise explanation and recommended next step
- prefill draft actions for review
- dedupe, snooze, and cool down repeated alerts
- maintain its own run and alert memory

What must always require confirmation?

FleetGraph must always pause before:

- creating or editing Ship documents
- changing issue state, assignee, sprint, or priority
- approving or requesting changes on plans, reviews, or retros
- notifying people beyond the directly responsible chain
- creating persistent comments, follow-up issues, or external messages

How does the agent know who is on a project?

FleetGraph should derive project membership from Ship's graph, not from a separate membership table:

- `owner_id` and `accountable_id` on program/project/week documents
- `consulted_ids` and `informed_ids` on program/project documents
- sprint owner from sprint properties
- issue assignees from issue properties
- person documents and `reports_to` for management chain
- team allocation and accountability views for who is active in a sprint or project

How does the agent know who to notify?

Notification order should be:

1. **Responsible** person first
2. **Accountable** person if the issue crosses a risk threshold or sits unresolved
3. **Manager/director** only when the accountable chain has stalled or the impact is cross-project
4. **Informed** roles only for high-signal summaries, not raw alert spam

How does the on-demand mode use context from the current view?

The current view is the graph entry point:

- **Issue view**: start with the issue, then expand to sprint, project, program, assignee, activity, and blockers
- **Week view**: start with the week, then expand to issues, standups, plan/review state, owner, and approvals
- **Project view**: start with the project, then expand to child weeks, issues, target date, approvals, and relevant learnings/feedback
- **Program view**: start with the program, then rank child project and week risk
- **My Week / person context**: start with the person, then expand to current accountability items, allocations, and due work

Design conclusion: Agent Responsibility Statement

FleetGraph is responsible for:

> detecting execution drift in Ship's document graph, explaining why it matters, identifying the right human to act, and making the next action obvious in context.

FleetGraph is not responsible for:

- replacing human ownership
- replacing Ship's existing accountability engine
- acting as a workspace-wide open-ended chatbot

2. Use Case Discovery

The strongest use cases are already implied by how Ship works today. These are discovered from the current Ship product model: accountability gaps, approval workflows, sprint drift, ownership, and intake/triage state.

This section directly answers:

- Think about the roles: Director, PM, Engineer
- For each use case define: role, trigger, what the agent detects or produces, what the human decides

- Do not invent use cases - discover pain points first

Use Case	Role	Mode	Trigger	What FleetGraph detects or produces	What the human decides
Missing ritual with active work	Engineer	Proactive	Business day passes with active sprint issues and no standup or weekly doc	Surfaces the missing item, why it is due, and a deep link to the exact document to complete	Whether to act now or snooze
Sprint is drifting before anyone asks	PM	Proactive	Sprint has open work, low recent activity, missing review state, or unresolved changes requested	Produces a sprint risk summary with the top 3 causes and the most effective intervention	Whether to message owner, approve, request changes, or rebalance work
Explain why a sprint is at risk	PM	On-demand	User opens a week and invokes FleetGraph	Explains scope drift, stale issues, approval bottlenecks, missing rituals, and recommende d next steps	Which action to take and whether to apply a suggested draft
Identify where director attention is needed	Director	Proactive	Program has multiple active projects and one or more exceed risk threshold	Produces a ranked intervention brief: which project, why now, who owns it, and what	Whether to escalate, reassign, or ask for a review

Use Case	Role	Mode	Trigger	What FleetGraph detects or produces	What the human decides
				decision is blocked	
Prioritize director intervention in context	Director	On-demand	User opens a program or dashboard and asks where to focus	Produces a ranked list of projects/weeks by risk and names the required intervention	Which scope to drill into and who to contact
Turn a stale issue into an actionable next step	Engineer or PM	On-demand	User opens an issue and asks what is blocking it	Explains likely blockers from surrounding sprint/project context and drafts a concrete next-step comment or plan	Whether to post or edit the draft
Escalate intake that is sitting too long	PM	Proactive	External feedback remains in triage too long or matches active work but has no owner	Produces a triage recommendation with likely owning project/program and suggested disposition	Whether to accept, reject, assign, or create follow-up work

3. Trigger Model Decision

The trigger model has to match the nature of the failures we care about. Some FleetGraph findings should surface immediately because they are caused by a fresh mutation in Ship. Others only become meaningful because time passed and nobody acted. That is why the trigger decision is architectural, not incidental.

This section directly answers:

- When does the proactive agent run without a user present?
- Poll vs. webhook vs. hybrid - what are the tradeoffs?
- How stale is too stale for your use cases?
- What does your choice cost at 100 projects? At 1,000?

When does the proactive agent run without a user present?

The proactive agent should run without a user present in two cases:

- immediately after high-signal Ship mutations
- every 5 minutes as a scheduled backstop for time-based drift

That means the design uses a **hybrid trigger model**:

- **event-triggered** for mutation-based conditions
- **scheduled sweeps** for time-based and quiet-failure conditions

Poll vs. webhook vs. hybrid - what are the tradeoffs?

Event-only / webhook-only

- pro: fast and cheap for explicit changes
- con: misses failures caused by silence and time passing

Poll-only

- pro: simpler mental model and catches silent drift
- con: noisier, more expensive, and less timely for fresh mutations

Hybrid

- pro: combines fast mutation response with reliable time-based detection
- con: slightly more operational complexity

Hybrid is the defensible choice because important failures in Ship are caused by both mutations and silence:

- nobody posted the standup yet
- no activity has happened for 3 days
- an approval has been waiting too long

Hybrid gives:

- fast detection for explicit state changes
- reliable backstop for time-based drift
- lower LLM cost because not every sweep becomes a reasoning run

How stale is too stale for your use cases?

Initial thresholds:

- standup missing: same business day
- weekly plan due: by the configured pre-start window or due day
- approval pending: 2 business days
- changes requested unresolved: 1 business day
- blocked/stale issue in active sprint: 2 days with no relevant movement
- active sprint/project with low activity: 3 days with open work
- triage feedback untouched: 2 days

What does your choice cost at 100 projects? At 1,000?

Assumptions:

- roughly 1 active workspace per 5 projects
- 20 active workspaces at 100 projects
- 200 active workspaces at 1,000 projects
- 288 scheduled sweeps per workspace per day at a 5-minute interval

Rough sweep counts:

- 100 projects: `20 * 288 = 5,760` scheduled sweeps per day
- 1,000 projects: `200 * 288 = 57,600` scheduled sweeps per day

This is only viable if:

- scheduled sweeps are **rules-first**
- most sweeps terminate without an LLM call
- the LLM only runs when a detector already found a meaningful anomaly

That is the key cost control decision in this architecture.

Phase 2: Graph Architecture

4. Node Design

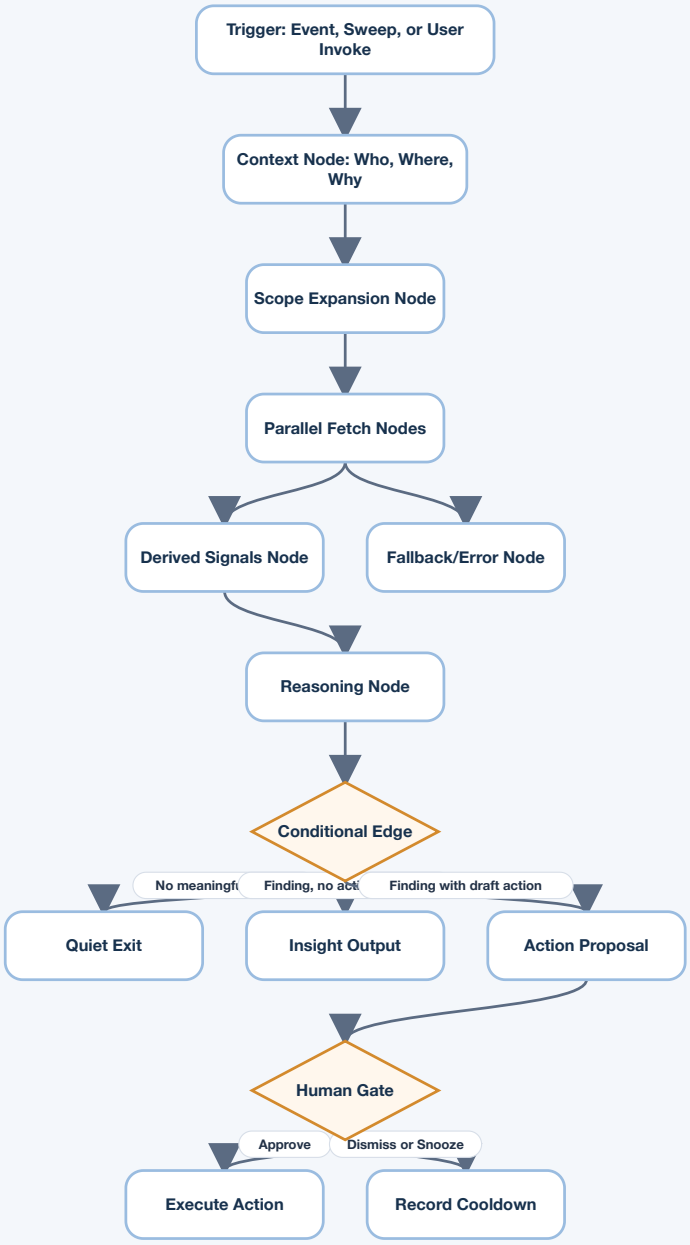
The graph should stay the same across proactive and on-demand mode so that the agent reasons consistently. The difference between modes should be the trigger and the initial context, not a completely different workflow. That keeps observability, behavior, and maintenance simpler.

This section directly answers:

- What are your context, fetch, reasoning, action, and output nodes?
- Which fetch nodes run in parallel?

- Where are your conditional edges and what triggers each branch?

Both proactive and on-demand mode should use the same graph. The difference is how the run starts.



FleetGraph graph flow

What are your context, fetch, reasoning, action, and output nodes?

Node	Purpose	Notes
`init_context`	Identify mode, trigger, viewer/service actor, workspace, current entity	Same node for proactive and on-demand
`expand_scope`	Resolve relevant program/project/week/person/issue scope from current entity or event	Graph-first, not page-first
`fetch_entity_context`	Load the current entity and core relationships	REST-only
`fetch_accountability_signals`	Pull accountability items, approval state, weekly doc state	Runs in parallel
`fetch_activity_signals`	Pull recent activity, status changes, stale patterns	Runs in parallel
`fetch_people_roles`	Resolve responsible, accountable, manager chain, and active participants	Runs in parallel
`fetch_supporting_context`	Pull learnings, search hits, feedback, or related docs when needed	Runs in parallel and only when relevant
`derive_metrics`	Turn raw API data into deterministic signals	No LLM here
`reason_about_state`	Claude reasons about risk, causality, and next action	Actual analysis node
`route_by_outcome`	Branch based on whether there is a meaningful finding	Must produce visibly different paths
`compose_insight`	Build proactive card or on-demand answer	Context-aware output
`prepare_action`	Draft a comment, follow-up item, assignment suggestion, or escalation	Proposal, not execution

Node	Purpose	Notes
`human_gate`	Present evidence and wait for confirmation	Required before consequential mutations
`execute_action`	Perform the approved API call	Revalidate state immediately before mutate
`persist_memory`	Store dedupe key, snooze, cooldown, and trace metadata	Agent-side state
`fallback`	Handle API failure, missing data, or reasoning uncertainty	Must degrade gracefully

Grouped by type:

- **Context nodes**
- `init_context`
- `expand_scope`
- **Fetch nodes**
- `fetch_entity_context`
- `fetch_accountability_signals`
- `fetch_activity_signals`
- `fetch_people_roles`
- `fetch_supporting_context`
- **Reasoning nodes**
- `derive_metrics`
- `reason_about_state`
- **Action nodes**
- `prepare_action`
- `execute_action`
- `persist_memory`
- **Output nodes**
- `compose_insight`
- `fallback`

Which fetch nodes run in parallel?

These should run in parallel whenever they are all needed:

- entity context

- accountability signals
- activity signals
- people/role resolution
- supporting context search

Where are your conditional edges and what triggers each branch?

The graph should branch at least on:

- no issue found -> quiet exit
- issue found but low severity -> insight only
- issue found with draftable action -> human gate
- insufficient confidence -> explain uncertainty and ask narrower question
- API/data failure -> fallback path

5. State Management

FleetGraph needs enough state to reason coherently within a run, but it should not become a second source of truth for project data. Ship remains the source of truth. FleetGraph should only persist operational memory: dedupe, cooldowns, snoozes, and run metadata.

This section directly answers:

- What state does the graph carry across a session?
- What state persists between proactive runs?
- How do you avoid redundant API calls?

What state does the graph carry across a session?

The graph should carry:

- mode: proactive or on-demand
- trigger type: event, sweep, or user invoke
- workspace ID
- actor identity: user session or service account
- current entity type and ID
- expanded scope IDs
- fetched API payloads
- derived metrics
- reasoning result
- proposed actions
- notification targets
- human approval status
- trace metadata and error state

What state persists between proactive runs?

Persist only operational state, not Ship domain truth:

- last finding signature per scope
- last surfaced timestamp
- snooze state
- cooldown window
- last successful run timestamp
- cached role/entity maps
- trace IDs and run summaries

This should live in a small FleetGraph-owned state store, not in Ship's domain model.

How do you avoid redundant API calls?

- resolve scope first, then fetch only relevant subgraphs
- parallelize fetches instead of chaining them
- cache stable relationship lookups briefly
- keep scheduled sweeps rules-first and only invoke Claude on suspicious scopes
- revalidate only the mutation target before action execution

6. Human-in-the-Loop Design

The human-in-the-loop layer is what keeps FleetGraph useful without making it reckless. The agent should be proactive and opinionated, but anything that changes project state or escalates people needs an explicit pause point. In other words, FleetGraph should be strong on detection and recommendation, conservative on mutation.

This section directly answers:

- Which actions require confirmation?
- What does the confirmation experience look like in Ship?
- What happens if the human dismisses or snoozes?

Which actions require confirmation?

- create comment or document draft in Ship
- create follow-up issue
- change assignee, sprint, or state
- request changes or approve
- escalate to manager or broader audience

What does the confirmation experience look like in Ship?

The confirmation should appear in existing context surfaces, not a new chatbot page:

- right-side properties/context panel for document views
- dashboard sidebar or action item modal for dashboard/program contexts

Each confirmation should show:

- the finding
- the evidence
- the exact proposed action
- the exact target object
- approve / edit / snooze / dismiss controls

What happens if the human dismisses or snoozes?

- `dismiss`: close the current proposal and record that it was reviewed
- `snooze`: suppress the same finding key until either the snooze expires or the underlying state changes materially

7. Error and Failure Handling

Error handling matters more here than in a normal feature because FleetGraph will run when no user is present and will often make decisions under incomplete context. The goal is not just to avoid crashing. The goal is to degrade in a way that stays trustworthy: admit uncertainty, reduce scope, and avoid confident bad actions.

This section directly answers:

- What does the agent do when Ship API is down?
- How does it degrade gracefully?
- What gets cached and for how long?

What does the agent do when Ship API is down?

FleetGraph should:

- fail the run gracefully
- record the failure in LangSmith and run logs
- retry with backoff
- only surface an operator-facing alert after repeated failures

How does it degrade gracefully?

FleetGraph should:

- say what context is missing
- avoid confident recommendations based on partial evidence
- fall back to a narrower insight instead of hallucinating a full diagnosis

What gets cached and for how long?

Short-lived caches only:

- role and person lookups: 10 to 15 minutes
- entity payloads for active scopes: 30 to 60 seconds
- activity and accountability rollups: up to 5 minutes
- learnings/search results: 5 to 10 minutes

Never trust cached state when mutating Ship. Re-fetch the exact mutation target before execution.

Phase 3: Stack and Deployment

8. Deployment Model

The deployment model should reflect the fact that FleetGraph has two different entry paths. Proactive runs need an always-available runtime that is not tied to a browser session. On-demand runs need to inherit the current user's context and permissions. The cleanest design is a shared graph implementation with two invocation surfaces.

This section directly answers:

- Where does the proactive agent run when no user is present?
- How is it kept alive?
- How does it authenticate with Ship without a user session?

Where does the proactive agent run when no user is present?

FleetGraph should run as a **dedicated worker service**, not inside a user request handler.

Why:

- proactive runs must happen without a user present
- retries, cooldowns, and sweeps should not live on the request path
- scaled API instances make in-process schedulers harder to reason about

How is it kept alive?

- always-on worker process
- internal scheduler for 5-minute sweeps
- event queue or internal enqueue path for high-signal mutation events

How does it authenticate with Ship without a user session?

The proactive worker should authenticate to Ship using a service account or API token with least-privilege workspace access.

This is important:

- proactive mode should not impersonate random users
- on-demand mode should still use the invoking user's session and permissions

Supporting design detail: how on-demand mode runs

On-demand mode should run through a Ship API endpoint that invokes the same graph code, but with:

- the current user session
- the current view context
- the user's role and visibility constraints

9. Performance

FleetGraph only works as a project intelligence tool if it is timely enough to matter and cheap enough to keep running. That means the performance story is not only about latency. It is also about when Claude is invoked, how much context is passed, and how often the same unchanged condition is re-analyzed.

This section directly answers:

- How does your trigger model achieve the < 5 minute detection latency goal?
- What is your token budget per invocation?
- Where are the cost cliffs in your architecture?

How does your trigger model achieve the `< 5 minute` detection latency goal?

- mutation-based detections are event-triggered and should surface near immediately
- time-based detections use a 5-minute sweep backstop
- sweeps stay fast because they are deterministic-first and scoped to active work

What is your token budget per invocation?

Initial target budgets:

- proactive anomaly run: `6k to 10k` input tokens, `500 to 1.2k` output tokens
- on-demand scoped analysis: `8k to 15k` input tokens, `800 to 1.5k` output tokens

Rules-first passes should consume **zero LLM tokens**.

Where are the cost cliffs in your architecture?

The main cost cliffs are:

- invoking Claude on every scheduled sweep
- fetching and passing entire project histories into the prompt
- repeated alerts on unchanged findings
- broad program analysis without first narrowing to suspicious projects

Mitigations:

- deterministic prefilter before reasoning
- dedupe and cooldown memory
- aggressive scope trimming
- cached summaries for repeated on-demand questions

Preliminary Architecture Decisions

These are the decisions I would carry into implementation:

1. **Use LangGraph**

- It fits the requirement directly and gives branching plus LangSmith tracing with less custom work.

1. **Use a hybrid trigger model**

- Event-triggered for mutations, scheduled sweeps for time-based drift.

1. **Keep the agent focused on execution drift**

- Not broad “ask me anything” chat.

1. **Use deterministic detectors before Claude**

- The LLM should reason about flagged contexts, not act as the detector for every run.

1. **Embed chat in existing context surfaces**

- right-side context/properties panels
- dashboard or action-item surfaces
- no standalone chatbot route

1. **Do not auto-mutate Ship state without approval**

- FleetGraph can surface and draft, but consequential changes stay human-approved.

1. **Use Ship REST APIs only for Ship data**

- any persistence for FleetGraph should be operational state only.

Open Risks to Validate at MVP

- Which Ship routes are the cleanest event hooks for proactive enqueueing
- Whether a service account/API token path is already sufficient for worker auth
- How much context can be sent before on-demand answers become too slow or too expensive

- Which notification surface feels most native in the existing 4-panel layout
- Whether program-level proactive summaries should be direct notifications or only appear in a director-facing dashboard/sidebar

Summary

FleetGraph should be built as a **context-aware execution intelligence agent** for Ship.

It should:

- monitor execution drift proactively
- reason from the current view on demand
- explain why a scope matters now
- identify the right human to act
- make the next action obvious

It should not:

- become a generic chatbot
- duplicate Ship's existing accountability engine
- mutate project state without review

That is the smallest version of FleetGraph that is both useful and defensible.